MLOps Assignment 1 — Heart Disease Risk Prediction: End-to-End MLOps Pipeline

AIMLCZG523 Machine Learning Operations · BITS Pilani · 50 marks

Student ID: 2025ae05082 · **Code repository:** https://github.com/krxthx/2025ae05082-MLOps-Assignment-1

Problem. Predict the presence of heart disease (binary) from 13 clinical features of the UCI Heart Disease (Cleveland) dataset, 303 patients, and ship the model as a containerised, monitored, Kubernetes-deployed API with experiment tracking and CI.

Stack. scikit-learn pipelines · MLflow · FastAPI · pytest · flake8 · GitHub Actions · Docker · Kubernetes (Minikube) · Prometheus · Grafana.

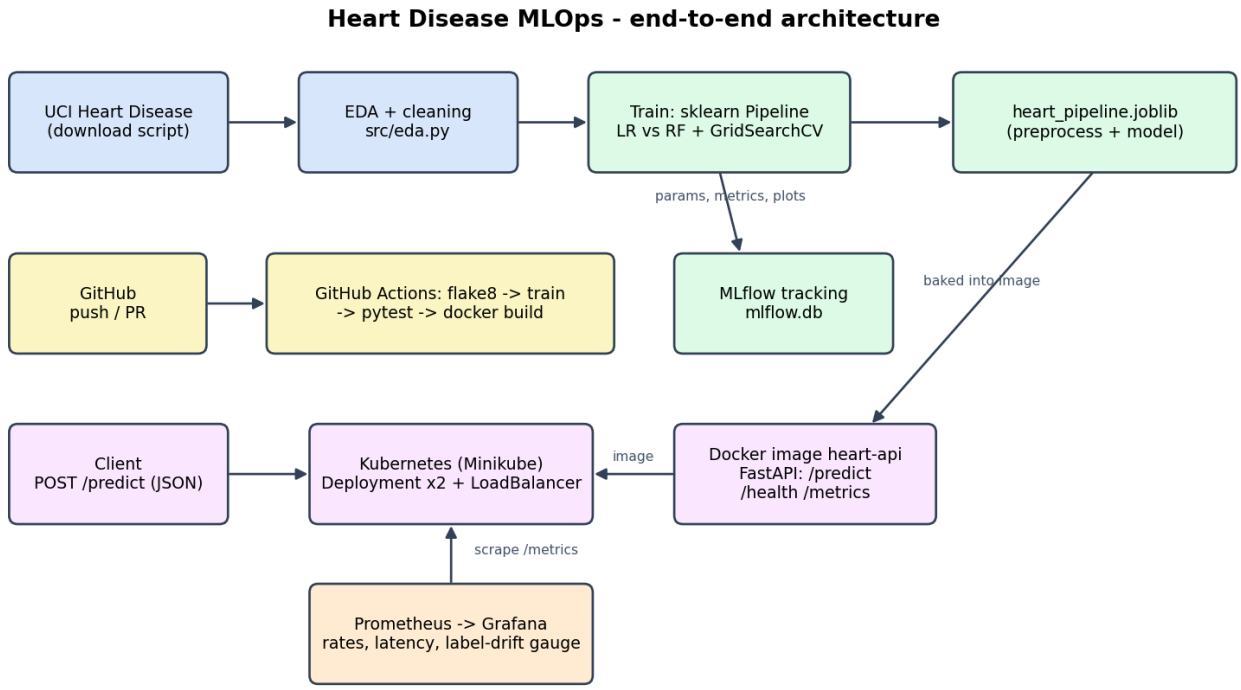


Figure 1 — Architecture. Data is downloaded and cleaned, a single scikit-learn `Pipeline` (preprocessing + classifier) is tuned and cross-validated with every run logged to MLflow, and the winning pipeline is serialised and baked into a Docker image. The image is deployed to Kubernetes and scraped by Prometheus, with Grafana on top. GitHub Actions re-runs lint → train → test → docker build on every push.

1. Setup and installation

Everything runs from a clean checkout using only `requirements.txt` (pinned versions). Python 3.11–3.13 tested.

```
git clone https://github.com/krxthx/2025ae05082-MLOps-Assignment-1.git && cd 2025ae05082-
        MLOps-Assignment-1
python -m venv .venv && source .venv/bin/activate
pip install -r requirements.txt
```

```
python src/data_download.py      # -> data/heart.csv (303 x 14)
python src/eda.py                # -> screenshots/eda_*.png
python src/train.py              # tuning + 5-fold CV + MLflow ->
        models/heart_pipeline.joblib
pytest -q                        # 7 tests
python -m flake8 src tests --max-line-length=120 --extend-ignore=E203,W503
uvicorn src.app:app --port 8000  # /health  /predict  /metrics
python src/inference.py --url http://localhost:8000
mlflow ui --backend-store-uri sqlite:///mlflow.db   # inspect runs, plots, artifacts
```

`requirements-serve.txt` is a slim subset (no MLflow / matplotlib / seaborn) used for the serving image. `mlflow.db` is generated by `train.py` and intentionally not committed (see §6, lesson 2).

Repository layout

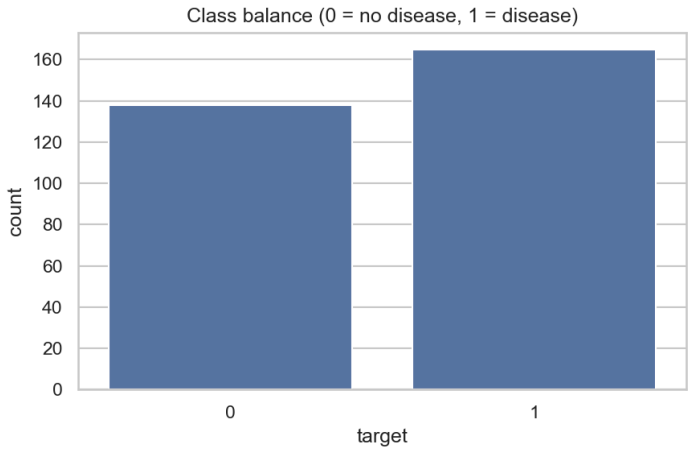
Path	Purpose
`src/`	`data_download.py`, `eda.py`, `preprocessing.py`, `train.py`, `app.py` (API), `inference.py`, `make_architecture.py`
`tests/test_all.py`	unit + API tests (pytest)
`.github/workflows/ci.yml`	lint → train → test → docker build → upload artifacts
`Dockerfile`, `docker-compose.yml`	serving image; API + Prometheus + Grafana stack
`k8s/`	`deployment.yaml` (2 replicas, probes, limits), `service.yaml` (LoadBalancer)
`monitoring/`	Prometheus scrape config + auto-provisioned Grafana datasource and dashboard
`data/`, `models/`, `screenshots/`, `notebooks/`	cleaned dataset, saved model + metrics, evidence, EDA/training notebook

2. Data acquisition and EDA (Task 1)

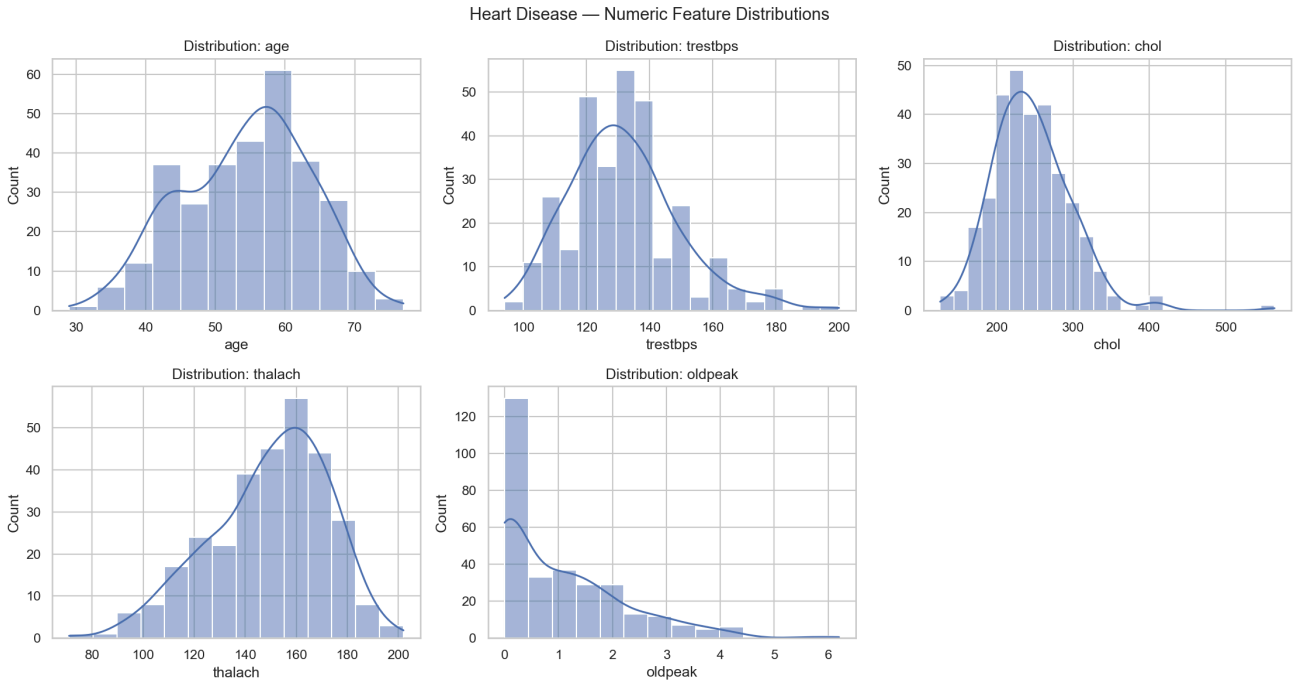
Acquisition. `src/data_download.py` downloads the UCI Heart Disease data (a clean CSV mirror first, then the original `processed.cleveland.data` with `?` → NaN handling and the 0–4 target binarised to 0/1), caches it as `data/heart.csv`, and fails loudly if no source is reachable. Columns: `age sex cp trestbps chol fbs restecg thalach exang oldpeak slope ca thal` plus `target`.

Cleaning. The 303-row snapshot has no missing values and no duplicates (checked in `eda.py`). Even so, the pipeline imputes (median for numeric, most-frequent for categorical) so the API remains robust to partial input at serving time. `ca` and `thal` are kept as categorical codes.

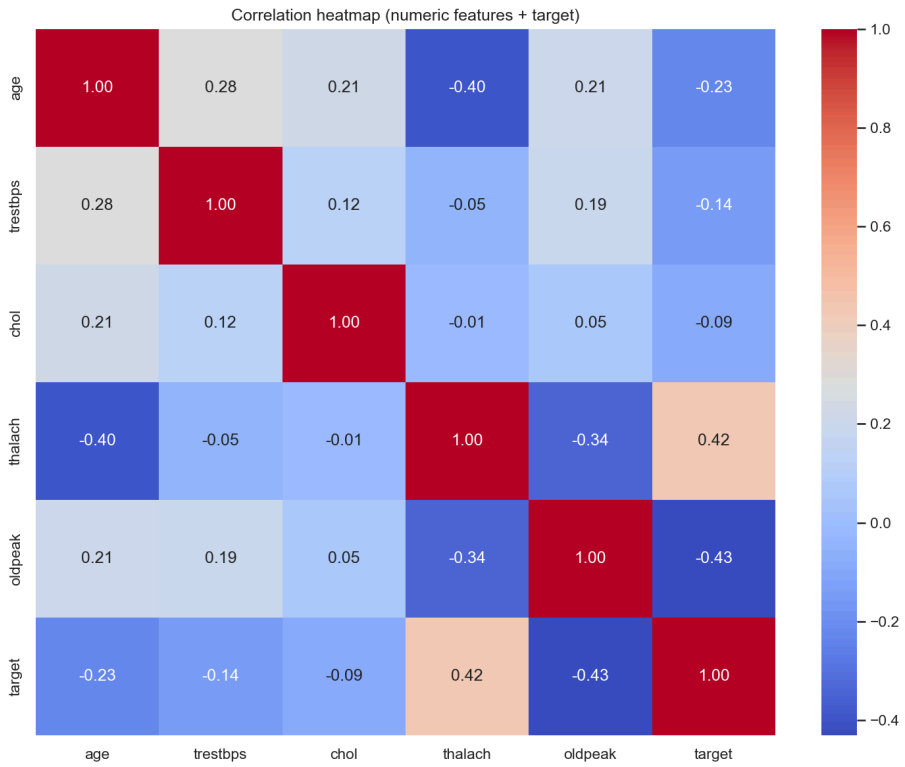
EDA findings (all figures are produced by `python src/eda.py`):



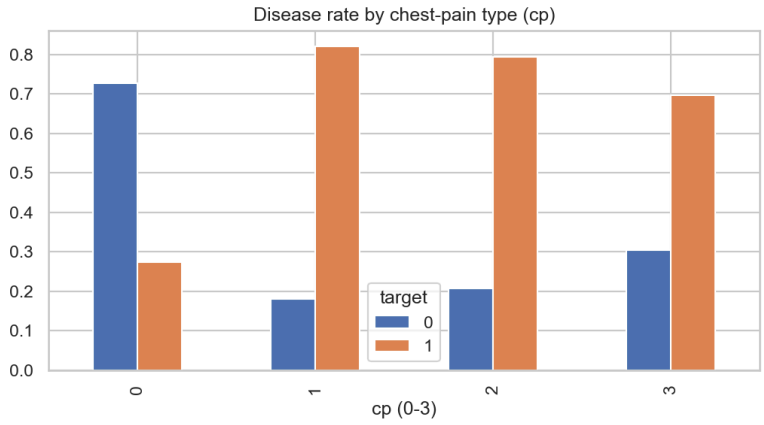
Class balance: 165 disease (54.5 %) vs 138 healthy (45.5 %). Mild imbalance, so no resampling; stratified CV is used everywhere and recall/precision are reported alongside accuracy.



Histograms: `chol` is right-skewed (max 564) and `oldpeak` is zero-inflated, which motivates `StandardScaler` on the numeric block rather than raw values.



Correlation heatmap: `thalach` (max heart rate) is negatively related to age and to the label, while `exang`, `oldpeak` and `cp` carry the strongest positive signal. This matches clinical intuition (exercise-induced angina, ST depression).



Chest-pain type vs target: the Cleveland sample has the lowest disease rate for typical angina (cp = 0) and higher rates for the other types, a known quirk of this dataset. One-hot encoding lets the models learn it without hand-coded assumptions.

One further observation matters for operations: **the CSV is sorted by target** (the first 120 rows are all positive). Any ordered split would be badly biased, which is another reason all evaluation uses shuffled, stratified folds. I also hit this when generating demo traffic for monitoring (§9).

3. Feature engineering and model development (Task 2)

Preprocessing (`src/preprocessing.py`) is a single `ColumnTransformer` that is part of the saved model, so training and serving cannot drift apart:

- numeric `age, trestbps, chol, thalach, oldpeak` → median impute → `StandardScaler`

- categorical `sex, cp, fbs, restecg, exang, slope, ca, thal` → most-frequent impute → `OneHotEncoder(handle_unknown="ignore")`

Models. (a) Logistic Regression: a calibrated, interpretable linear baseline. (b) Random Forest: a non-linear comparator. I deliberately skipped gradient boosting: with n = 303 it adds variance and tuning burden without a realistic gain, and for a clinical-adjacent task auditability matters.

Tuning. Each model's full pipeline is tuned with `GridSearchCV` (stratified 5-fold, scoring = ROC-AUC, fixed seed):

Model	Grid	Best	CV ROC-AUC
Logistic Regression	`C` ∈ {0.01, 0.1, 1, 10}	`C = 1.0`	0.9174 (C=0.01: 0.904, 0.1: 0.916, 10: 0.916)
Random Forest	`n_estimators` ∈ {100, 200, 400} × `max_depth` ∈ {None, 4, 8}	`max_depth = 4`, `n_estimators = 200`	0.9178 (unrestricted depth: ≈ 0.906–0.909)

Two things stand out. Logistic Regression is flat across `C` ≥ 0.1, so the result is not sensitive to regularisation. For Random Forest, **shallow trees beat unrestricted ones** (0.914–0.918 vs ≈ 0.907), a typical small-data overfitting signature, so depth was capped. The full grids are stored per run as the `grid_results.csv` artifact in MLflow.

Evaluation. Final metrics use stratified 5-fold cross-validation (`cross_validate`) with accuracy, precision, recall and ROC-AUC. ROC-AUC is computed from predicted probabilities.

Model	Accuracy	Precision	Recall	ROC-AUC
Logistic Regression (tuned)	**0.865**	**0.862**	**0.909**	0.917
Random Forest (tuned)	0.842	0.840	0.885	**0.918**

Model selection. The rule is "highest CV ROC-AUC", which selects **Random Forest** (`models/best_model.txt`). The margin is 0.0004 AUC, far inside fold-to-fold noise, so the two models are statistically indistinguishable on discrimination. Logistic Regression is better on accuracy, precision and recall. I kept a single pre-declared rule instead of picking the metric after the fact; if a clinician preferred the higher-recall, more explainable linear model, switching is a one-line change to the selection criterion in `train.py`. Note that the grid-search scores and the reported CV metrics use the same folds, so the numbers are mildly optimistic; with only 303 rows I chose not to spend data on a separate nested split, and say so here.

4. Experiment tracking (Task 3)

`train.py` logs to MLflow with a SQLite backend (`sqlite:///mlflow.db`, experiment `heart-disease`). SQLite is used because MLflow ≥ 2.19 retired the flat-file store. Each run records:

- **Parameters:** every estimator hyper-parameter (`<model>__*`) plus the tuned `best__clf__*` values;
- **Metrics:** accuracy, precision, recall, ROC-AUC, `grid_best_roc_auc`, `fit_seconds`;
- **Artifacts:** the fitted sklearn pipeline (`MLmodel`, `model.pkl`, `conda.yaml`, `requirements.txt`), `grid_results.csv`, an out-of-fold **ROC curve** and a **confusion matrix** (PNG, via

`mlflow.log_figure`).

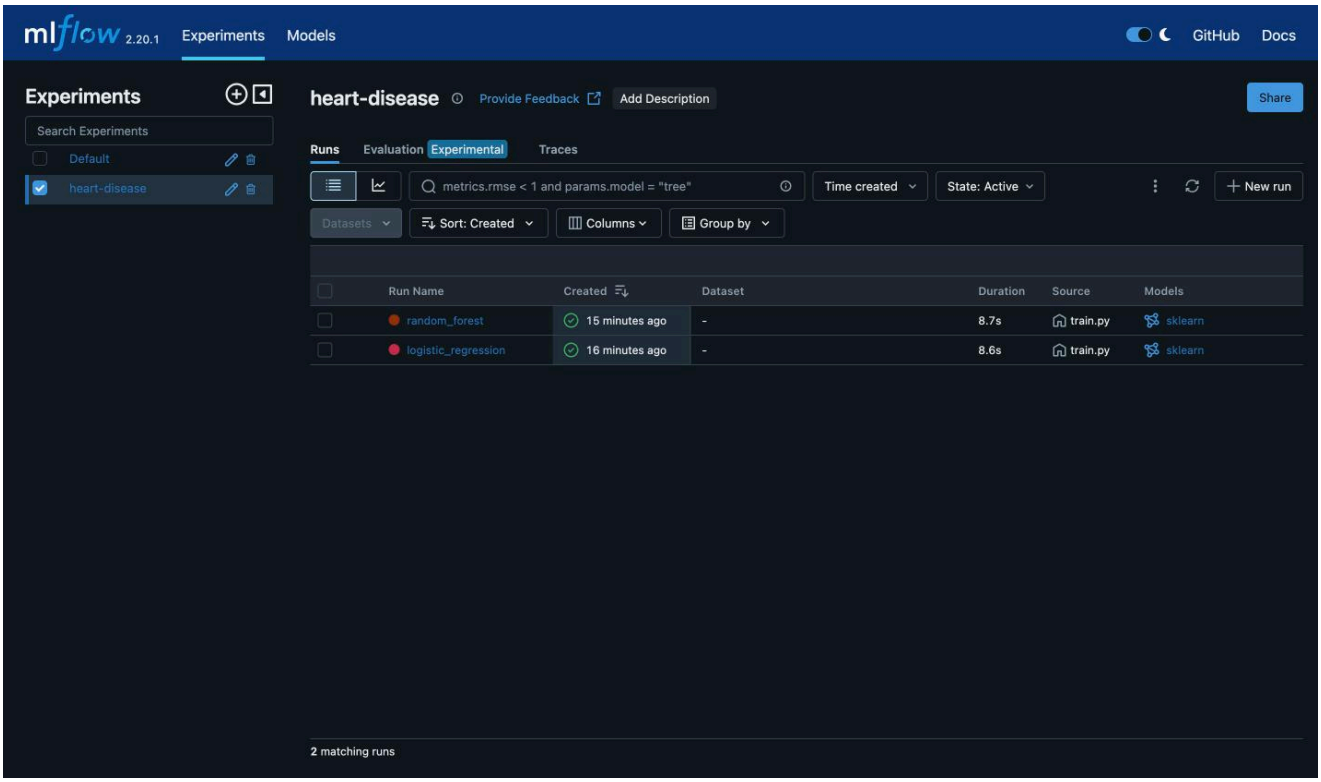


Figure — the `heart-disease` experiment with one run per candidate model.



Figure — side-by-side run comparison: tuned parameters (`best__clf__C` vs `best__clf__max_depth` / `best__clf__n_estimators`) and metrics.

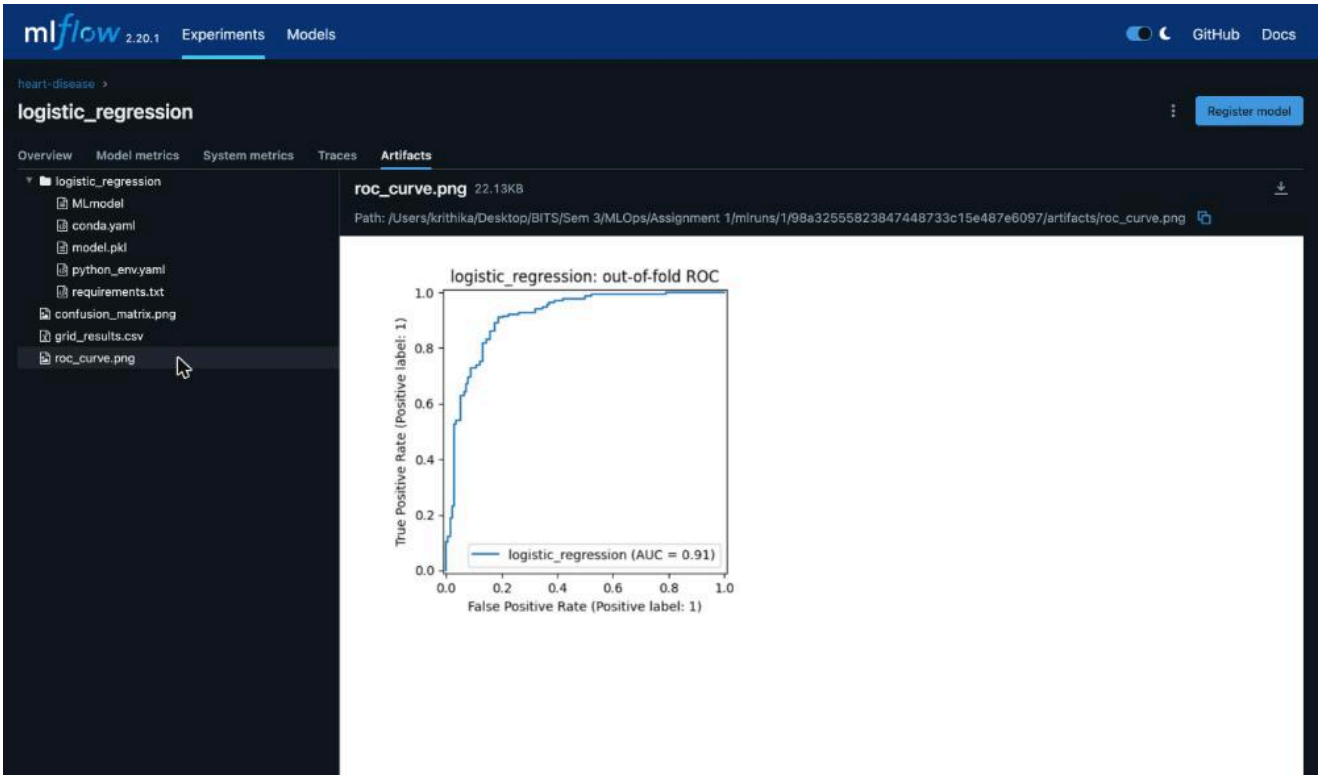


Figure — logged artifacts of the Logistic Regression run, showing the out-of-fold ROC curve (AUC = 0.91) and the model files.

5. Model packaging and reproducibility (Task 4)

- **Model format:** `models/heart_pipeline.joblib` is the entire preprocess + classifier `Pipeline`, accompanied by `models/metrics.json` and `models/best_model.txt`. The same pipeline is also logged to MLflow in MLflow's native format.
- **Environment:** `requirements.txt` pins every direct dependency, including a pin on `sqlalchemy==2.0.36` (see lesson 1 below). The serving environment pins the same scikit-learn / pandas / numpy as training. An earlier version mismatch (a `LogisticRegression.multi_class` unpickling error) was caught by the Docker smoke test.
- **Data lineage:** the download script, `data/heart.csv` and `data/sample_input.json` make the full path from raw source to prediction scriptable.
- **Notebook and client:** `notebooks/eda_training.ipynb` mirrors EDA and training interactively; `src/inference.py` is a smoke-test client for the live API.

6. CI/CD pipeline and automated testing (Task 5)

Unit tests (`tests/test_all.py`, 7 tests, all passing):

1. dataset contract: shape, expected columns, binary target, bounded missingness;
2. preprocessing: output has one row per input and expands the feature space (one-hot encoding);
3. preprocessing robustness: after injecting missing `chol` values, the transformed matrix contains no NaNs;
4. model quality gate: the saved pipeline clears a minimum accuracy (a sanity check on training data, not a generalisation estimate; that is what the cross-validation in §3 is for);

5. missing-value inference: the saved pipeline returns a valid probability for a row with a missing feature;
6. API: `/health`, `/predict` response schema and probability bounds, and `/metrics`, through FastAPI's `TestClient`;
7. API validation: out-of-range or incomplete JSON is rejected with HTTP 422.

Pipeline (`.github/workflows/ci.yml`, runs on every push and pull request): `checkout → setup-python 3.11 → pip install -r requirements.txt → flake8 → download data → train (MLflow) → pytest → docker build → upload metrics.json + screenshots as artifacts`. Any lint, training, test or build failure fails the workflow with the failing step's log (the "must fail on errors and give clear logs" requirement). The `upload-artifact` step uses `if: always()`, so evidence is kept even on failure.

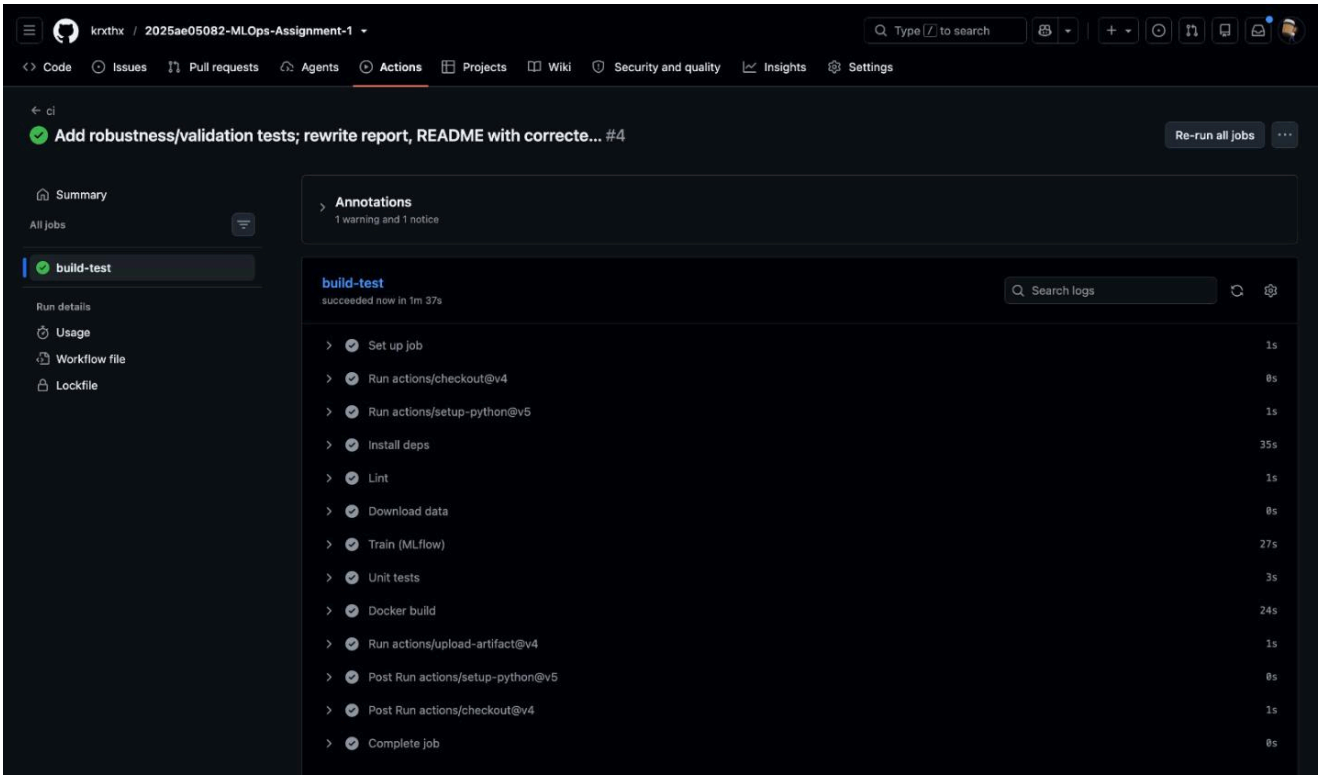


Figure — GitHub Actions run #4 on `main`: install, lint, download, train, tests and docker build all pass (1 m 40 s total).

What the first CI runs taught me. The first two runs on GitHub failed, although everything passed on my laptop. This is exactly what CI is for, and each failure was a genuine reproducibility bug:

1. **Unpinned transitive dependency.** On a fresh install pip picked SQLAlchemy 2.1, which MLflow 2.20.1 cannot import (`ImportError: FallbackAsyncAdaptedQueuePool`). Fix: pin `sqlalchemy==2.0.36`. My laptop had worked only because an older SQLAlchemy was already installed.
2. **Committed `mlflow.db` embedded an absolute path.** The tracking database stores each experiment's artifact location; mine was `/Users/<me>/...`, so on the runner MLflow tried to create `/Users` and died with `PermissionError`. Fix: the database is a generated artifact, so it is now git-ignored and recreated by `train.py`. The evidence is in the MLflow screenshots instead.
3. **Wrong ROC-AUC (found while reproducing).** My scorer called `roc_auc_score` on hard 0/1 predictions, not on probabilities, so the reported AUC was 0.860 while the grid search said 0.917 for the same model. Fixed by scoring from `predict_proba`. This changed the headline numbers and flipped the (near-tied) winner from Logistic Regression to Random Forest, and every table in this report reflects the corrected values.

7. Containerisation (Task 6)

The `Dockerfile` uses `python:3.11-slim`, installs only `requirements-serve.txt`, copies `src/` and the trained `models/`, defines a `HEALTHCHECK` on `/health`, and starts `uvicorn src.app:app` on port 8000.

The API (`src/app.py`) validates input with Pydantic (typed ranges per feature), exposes `POST /predict`, `GET /health` and `GET /metrics`, and returns the class, the probability (confidence) and a label:

```
$ docker build -t heart-api:latest .
$ docker run -d --name heart-test -p 8001:8000 heart-api:latest
$ curl localhost:8001/health
{"status":"ok"}
$ curl -X POST localhost:8001/predict -H 'Content-Type: application/json' -d
@data/sample_input.json
{"prediction":1,"probability":0.652,"label":"disease"}
```

The complete build/run/curl/log transcript is saved in `screenshots/docker_run.log`. Invalid input (e.g. `sex = 7`) is rejected with HTTP 422 before reaching the model.

8. Production deployment on Kubernetes (Task 7)

`k8s/deployment.yaml` defines 2 replicas, readiness and liveness probes on `/health`, CPU/memory requests and limits and `imagePullPolicy: IfNotPresent`; `k8s/service.yaml` exposes it as a `LoadBalancer` on port 80. I deployed to **Minikube** (Docker driver):

```
minikube image load heart-api:latest
kubectl apply -f k8s/
kubectl rollout status deployment/heart-api     # successfully rolled out
kubectl port-forward svc/heart-api 8002:80
```

```
NAME                             READY   STATUS    RESTARTS   AGE
pod/heart-api-7d65f76968-5gqh4   1/1     Running   0          18s
pod/heart-api-7d65f76968-ww2s4   1/1     Running   0          18s
service/heart-api   LoadBalancer   10.102.9.152   <pending>   80:31734/TCP

$ curl localhost:8002/health   -> {"status":"ok"}
$ curl -X POST localhost:8002/predict -d @data/sample_input.json
{"prediction":1,"probability":0.652,"label":"disease"}
```

Full output, including `kubectl logs`, is in `screenshots/k8s_pods.txt`. The service stays `<pending>` for its external IP, which is normal on Minikube without `minikube tunnel`; port-forward is the access path. **Access instructions for the API (local):** the commands above, then `http://localhost:8002/docs` for the interactive OpenAPI UI. The same manifests work unchanged on GKE/EKS/AKS after pushing the image to a registry and changing the `image:` field.

Pitfall worth recording: `minikube image load` does not overwrite an existing `heart-api:latest`. After retraining, the pods kept serving the old model (probability 0.8471 instead of 0.652) until I ran `minikube image rm` first. In production this is the argument for immutable image tags (the git SHA) instead of `:latest`.

9. Monitoring and logging (Task 8)

- **Logging.** Every `/predict` call emits one structured log line (timestamp, full input, prediction, probability); in Kubernetes: `kubectl logs deploy/heart-api`.
- **Metrics.** `/metrics` exposes `heart_predictions_total{label}` and the `heart_predict_latency_seconds` histogram, plus default process metrics (CPU, memory).
- **Stack.** `docker compose up --build` starts the API, Prometheus (scraping `heart-api:8000` every 15 s) and Grafana, with the datasource (uid pinned to `prometheus`) and the dashboard auto-provisioned, so no manual setup is needed (login `admin` / `admin`; host ports are overridable with `API_PORT`, `PROM_PORT`, `GRAFANA_PORT`).

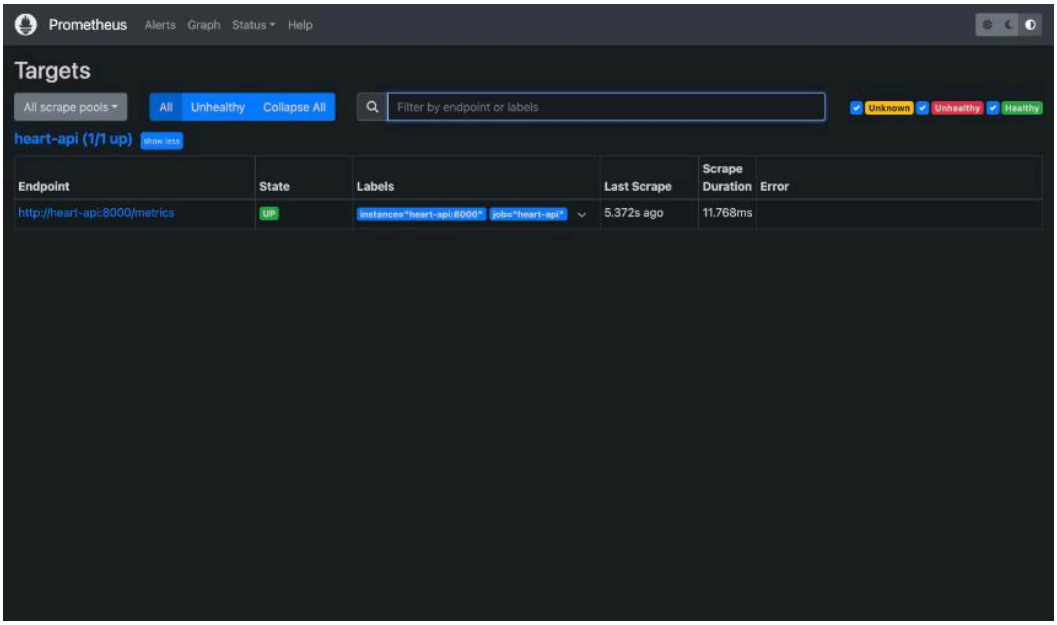


Figure — Prometheus target `heart-api:8000/metrics` is UP.



Figure — Grafana "Heart Disease API — Monitoring" after replaying the 303 dataset rows through `/predict`: 303 total predictions (176 disease / 127 no-disease), p95 latency ≈ 49 ms, request-rate and latency-percentile time series, label distribution, process CPU, and a disease-rate gauge (58.1 %) that doubles as a simple label-drift indicator.

Two defects in the provisioned dashboard were found only by actually opening it, and fixed: every panel showed an error because the dashboard referenced datasource uid `prometheus` while Grafana had generated a random uid, and the disease-rate gauge showed "No data" because it divided two series with different `label` values (fixed with `sum()` on both sides).

10. Conclusion and limitations

All nine tasks are implemented and verified end to end: data → EDA → tuned, cross-validated models → MLflow → packaged pipeline → tested/linted CI → Docker → Kubernetes → Prometheus/Grafana.

Honest limitations: (1) n = 303 is small, so CV estimates have wide error bars and the two models are effectively tied (§3); (2) tuning and reporting share folds, so scores are mildly optimistic; (3) the label-drift gauge monitors predicted class mix only, because ground truth is not available at serving time; (4) the deployment is local (Minikube) rather than on a public cloud, and uses `:latest` rather than immutable tags; (5) this is a teaching model and must not be used for clinical decisions.

11. Deliverables checklist

Deliverable	Location
GitHub repository	https://github.com/krxthx/2025ae05082-MLOps-Assignment-1
Code, Dockerfile, requirements	`src/`, `Dockerfile`, `requirements.txt`, `requirements-serve.txt`
Dataset + download script	`data/heart.csv`, `src/data_download.py`
Notebooks / scripts (EDA, training, inference)	`notebooks/eda_training.ipynb`, `src/eda.py`, `src/train.py`, `src/inference.py`
Unit tests	`tests/test_all.py`
GitHub Actions workflow	`.github/workflows/ci.yml`
Deployment manifests	`k8s/deployment.yaml`, `k8s/service.yaml`, `docker-compose.yml`
Screenshots	`screenshots/`
Report	`REPORT.md` / `REPORT.pdf`
Deployed API access	local Minikube: `kubectl port-forward svc/heart-api 8002:80` (§8)
Demo video (silent walkthrough, 2 min: data → train → MLflow → tests → CI → Docker → Kubernetes → monitoring; assembled from real command output and screenshots)	`demo/pipeline_walkthrough.mp4`